



Douglas County Libraries

The Martha's Vineyard
Beach and Book Club
by Martha Hall Kelly

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Discussion Questions

1. The Martha's Vineyard Beach and Book Club has a contemporary storyline—set in 2016—framing the story, but the majority of the novel follows the Smith sisters during World War II. Why do you think Martha Hall Kelly chose to add a contemporary thread to the novel? Were you surprised by how the two storylines came together in the end?
2. Many historical fiction novels set during World War II are set in Europe. But *The Martha's Vineyard Beach and Book Club* is set on US shores. Were you aware of war efforts happening off the coast of Martha's Vineyard? Did it change your understanding of American soldiers during this specific time in history?
3. Kelly populates the book with very strong female characters. Which character's journey resonated with you the most? Why?
4. The inspiring power of book clubs and storytelling is a big theme in the narrative. What other overarching themes did you notice?
5. How did the wartime book club that Cadence and Bess prompt change for women in their community? How do you think of the books they chose to read influenced these changes?
6. Bess, Cadence's best friend and her brother Tom's girlfriend, comes from a wealthy family but left that life of privilege behind to work the land and live with the Smith sisters and Gram. Why do you think she did that? What did she learn?
7. How does the arrival of the U.S. Army shake things up for the Smith sisters and their neighbors on the island? What are the consequences of the Smith family hiding the mysterious soldier who washes up on their shores?
8. Cadence's love interest in the novel is a British serviceman, Major Gilbert. What secrets are they both hiding from each other, and how did you feel their story was resolved?
9. Briar has a great interest in submarines and is convinced that she's seeing them offshore even though no one believes her. How does her interest in the war shape her actions and decisions?
10. What are some key moments of growth for the main characters? How do they change throughout the novel?
11. What does the setting of Martha's Vineyard symbolize for the characters in both time periods? How does the island setting influence the story?
12. What message do you think the author is trying to impart about female friendships and family?
13. If you've read Martha Hall Kelly's historical fiction previously, how did this novel compare to her others?

Author Biography

Martha Hall Kelly is the New York Times bestselling author of LILAC GIRLS, LOST ROSES, SUNFLOWER SISTERS, THE GOLDEN DOVES and THE MARTHA'S VINEYARD BEACH AND BOOK CLUB. Born and raised in Massachusetts, she was inspired to write this novel by her mother's family, the Smiths, who settled on Martha's Vineyard in 1891. She received journalism degrees from both Syracuse and Northwestern universities and worked as an advertising copywriter for many years before becoming a novelist. With more than two million copies of her books sold and translated in 50 countries, Martha Hall Kelly lives in Litchfield, Connecticut, and Hobe Sound, Florida.

The Martha's Vineyard Beach and Book Club

Martha Hall Kelly

Kelly (*Lilac Girls*) delivers a transporting tale of a grieving 30-something woman who uncovers family secrets during a visit to Martha's Vineyard. After Mari Starwood's mother dies of an aneurysm in Los Angeles, she finds the name and address of famous painter Elizabeth Devereaux among her mother's belongings. Wondering what her mother's connection was to the painter, Mari travels across the country to meet the elderly woman on Martha's Vineyard. There, Elizabeth tells Mari the story of two sisters on the island during WWII—19-year-old aspiring writer Cadence Smith and her 16-year-old sister, Briar, who is obsessed with looking for German U-boats off the New England coast. Kelly adds plenty of intrigue to the plot, as Elizabeth reveals how Briar's interest in the enemy's activities gets her into serious trouble. Meanwhile, a tragic subplot follows the Smith girls' older brother, Tom, who ships out with the Navy just after getting his blue-blooded girlfriend pregnant. The connections between the story lines come into focus as Mari grapples with a newfound understanding of her relationship to the island. This twisty tale is not to be missed.

Read-Alikes

The Wartime Book Club by Kate Thompson

Ordered by the Nazis to destroy books that threaten the new regime, Grace, the Isle of Jersey's only librarian, instead forms the Wartime Book Club, offering fearful islanders the joy and escapism of reading, but when tensions turn to violence, she is forced to face the true, terrible cost of resistance.

The Air Raid Book Club by Annie Lyons

London, 1938: The bookstore just doesn't feel the same to Gertie ever since the death of her beloved husband Harry. Bingham Books was a dream they shared, and without Harry, Gertie wonders if it's time to retire to the seaside. But fate has other plans for Gertie. In Germany, Hitler is on the rise, and Jewish families are making the decision to send their children away from the growing turmoil. Gertie decides to take in one of these refugees, a teenage girl named Hedy. When the Blitz begins, Gertie and Hedy come up with the idea to start an air raid book club. They hold lively discussions. After all, a good book can do wonders to bolster people's spirits, even in the most trying times.

The Lost Letters From Martha's Vineyard by Michael Callahan

A novel about two women bound by blood but divided by a long-buried secret and about the island that holds the key to the fateful summer that changed everything forever.